PLAYBOOK 07 · TIER 4

Staffing & Incentive

The Pod Model — Sustainable Ownership Without Dedicated Headcount

Purpose

Define who actually does this work, how to keep it sustainable, when it justifies a dedicated hire, and how to compensate it fairly — a segment can't run on automation alone if nobody has designed the human layer with the same rigor.

Who's in the Pod

Ownership rotates among the regular CSM group on a quarterly cycle — not a standing sub-team or a dedicated hire at moderate volume. Enterprise CS stays out of rotation entirely; their time is protected for Tier 1/2 relationship work, and pulling them into Tier 4 triage defeats the purpose of tiering in the first place.

Cohort structure: accounts split by renewal month, not region. Region doesn't hold up as an organizing axis at this tier — the product questions here rarely require local knowledge the way a named relationship might, and renewal-month cohorts even out workload while tying each quarterly review directly to whichever slice of the base has active renewal risk that quarter.

Backup coverage: a named backup CSM covers absences and overflow. Pod duty is never a single point of failure.

Rotation handoff: the outgoing pod owner briefs the incoming one on any account currently mid-trigger or flagged for a manual renewal save — a short, defined handoff, not a cold start.

Keeping It Sustainable

- Dashboard reviewed on a fixed cadence — 2–3x weekly, not continuously monitored
- Only the most severe trigger tier interrupts outside that cadence; everything else batches into the next scheduled review
- A hard weekly cap on pod-duty hours, additive to the CSM's existing Tier 3 book — never allowed to quietly become a second full-time job
- Rotation length itself limits any one person's exposure to a rough quarter

When to Convert Rotation Into a Dedicated Hire

Rotation works because the pod owner is also carrying a real book elsewhere — it's additive, not their whole job. That breaks down at a specific point: when Tier 4 volume alone would occupy roughly a third or more of a full CSM's time, even with automation absorbing routine work.

The concrete signal: a quarterly cohort regularly generates more triggered tasks than the pod owner can close within the SLA window. That's measured evidence, not a guess.

One dedicated Tier 4 CSM, not a team, is the first step. A single dedicated specialist — pure triage, no other book — typically covers a meaningfully larger volume than a rotating generalist, since they're not context-switching between two segments.

A second hire (an actual small team) makes sense when: - Volume grows past what one dedicated specialist can realistically cover - The segment represents enough of total revenue that one person's absence becomes a real business risk

At that point, cohorts convert from rotating assignments to fixed, permanent ownership per person — the process has already been proven, so this is a scaling decision, not a redesign.

Retention vs. Expansion — Who Handles What

Action	Owner
Retention save	Pod owner, alone — no contract terms involved
In-plan upsell (seat, tier bump)	Automated in-app prompt, or a light nudge if already flagged — no human required
Contract-touching expansion	Pod owner flags and qualifies the signal; Sales runs the close
Named-CSM add-on line	Routed to Sales as a defined product, not an ad hoc negotiation

The rule: the pod owner owns retention alone. They source expansion signals but hand off anything touching a contract — keeping them out of negotiation territory they're not equipped or incentivized for, while still crediting them for the assist.

Incentive Structure

A shared quarterly pool, not an individual target — because nobody owns a fixed book at this tier, an individual bonus would unfairly penalize whoever drew a cohort with a rough renewal cluster that quarter.

Tied to: - Cohort renewal rate for the quarter held - Segment churn rate during that rotation - Expansion revenue sourced from the segment — credited even when Sales closed it

Structured as: - Split between the pod owner and their backup for that quarter - Sized meaningfully smaller than Tier 1–2 incentive structures, since this sits on top of an existing book rather than as someone's primary revenue responsibility - Never a straight individual target — the shared pool is the design, not a simplification

Artifacts

- Quarterly rotation schedule and cohort assignment
- Pod-duty handoff checklist
- Volume-tracking dashboard (trigger volume vs. SLA capacity, the conversion signal)
- Shared incentive pool calculation template

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